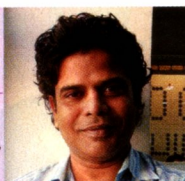


10 MOST EROTIC LITERATURE

Readers Digest

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Erotica does not assume a poverty of sexual imagination on the reader's part. It allows men and women to engage as equals and sets you in the mood for love. Here are my top 10 picks.

1 TWENTY LOVE POEMS AND A SONG OF DESPAIR BY PABLO NERUDA

To me it is not astonishing that these are the finest verses of the greatest poet in any language. But that at the tender age of 19, Neruda, could convey an understanding of desire that most people don't get to experience all their lives. I quote "I will bring you happy flowers from the mountains/ bluebells, dark hazels, and rustic baskets of kisses/ I want to do with you what spring does with the cherry trees." I mean, how can you write like that? I rest my case.

2 THE LAST NIGHT OF THE EARTH POEMS BY CHARLES BUKOWSKI

All right, I am cheating here. Actually, any Bukowski book of poems would do. The man whose grave-stone reads: "Don't Try", a phrase which Bukowski uses in one of his poems, advising aspiring writers and poets about inspiration and creativity, is effortless both in his living and his loving. But under the signature Bukowski dirt and grime glitters an understanding of desire that is dazzling.

3 LOLITA BY VLADIMIR NABOKOV

What can I say about this Nabokov classic that's not already been said and better? This celebration of the obsessive, devouring and doomed passion of Humbert Humbert is one of the most poignant, love-seared writing I have read, ever. There are times when prose comes pretty close to poetry. This is one of them.

4 ANOTHER E.E. CUMMINGS BY E.E. CUMMINGS

There is nothing unassuming about the erotic poetry of the man who chose to write only in lowercase, with a grammar and punctuation system of his own. The poem *She being brand new* is a particularly breathtaking example of Cummings' consummate craft.

5 THE TROPIC OF CANCER BY HENRY MILLER

Semi-autobiographical and set in the 1930's, it is a tale of Miller's life as a struggling writer. It was banned for 27 years in the prudish US of A, for it roller coaster ride into a sexuality so raw

and shocking that it will change any reader forever as a person.

6 MEMORIES OF MY MELANCHOLY WHORES BY GABRIEL GARCIA MARQUEZ

Written in the poetic and often magical narrative of Marquez, it tells an unlikely story, that of a 90-year-old man's love for a 14-year-old prostitute in a style that alternates between magic-realism, erotica and memoir. It is an outstanding account of the timelessness of desire.

7 KA BY ROBERTO CALASSO

In this astonishingly original book, Robert Calasso has used the body of colossal Sanskrit literature and turned into a novel. The output is a beautifully crafted tale on Hindu mythology which makes the story of creation sizzle with its prose.

8 THE BODY ARTIST BY DON DELILLO

I write to find out how much I know, DeLillo is fond of saying. And this man knows a lot, about a lot. Written three years after his ground breaking *Underworld*, this short novel is an eerie exploration of desire and loneliness. Probably it's strange for this book to be on a list of erotica. But it's my list. So, buzz off.

9 MY UNCLE OSWALD BY ROALD DAHL

When you mix the world's most powerful aphrodisiac with the world's most diabolical imagination, you get erotica that is rip roaring funny. Wit is a massive turn-on. And Dahl uses it to the hilt in this tale by a nameless narrator who tells the story of lovable, lascivious Uncle Oswald. This book is for anyone who likes a very lucid yet deliciously weird story.

10 KAFKA ON THE SHORE BY HARUKI MURAKAMI

Murakami is a 'complex cartographer of desire'. And due to the Oedipal theme running through much of the novel, *Kafka on the Shore* has been called a modern Greek tragedy. I found it utterly sad and strangely erotic. Or may be it's just me who is twisted.

